PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #62 · ABUSE

“I’m damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless.”

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Where it often comes from

Harm can leave shame that feels like a stain: damaged, ashamed, worthless. That feeling is common, and it is a lie about your worth. What was done to you does not make you less of a person. Shame often shows up because someone treated you as if you did not matter. God’s nearness to the brokenhearted is the opposite of that treatment. You do not have to recount what happened to question this sentence. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

God heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds. He does not rename them worthless. He is near the brokenhearted. Nothing can separate you from the love of God in Christ. Grace is sufficient in weakness. These verses do not rush you to feel clean. They refuse the conclusion that harm made you damaged goods.

> *“He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds”* (Psalm 147:3).

Also see

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

Common self-statements

- I am ruined and dirty.
- If people knew, they would be disgusted.
- I will never be worth kindness.
- The shame is proof that I am the problem.
- I should hide so I do not contaminate anyone.
- God cannot look at me.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling your whole self damaged because you were harmed.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and deciding the shame is the truth about you.
- Mind reading: Assuming everyone would reject you if they knew.

- Fortune telling: Deciding you will always be worthless.

Challenging questions

- What was done to me, and what have I decided that makes me?
- Would I call a friend worthless because someone harmed them?
- Is shame a fact, or a weight someone else put on me?
- What is still true and good about me?
- What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- Who is safe enough to tell that I feel ashamed, without telling the story?

Truth summary

> I was hurt, and I am not worthless. What was done to me does not decide what I am worth.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

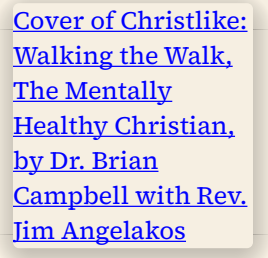
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Guilt/Shame
- Love, By God
- Hopeless
- Sorrow

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering
- Depression

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Broken Things — Matthew West
God does not throw away a wounded person.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
What God says about you is not "worthless."

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
What was done to you is not God's last word about you.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
Jesus loves you. Harm does not cancel that.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was done to me, and what have I decided that makes me?
- ☐ Would I call a friend worthless because someone harmed them?
- ☐ Is shame a fact, or a weight someone else put on me?
- ☐ What is still true and good about me?
- ☐ What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- ☐ Who is safe enough to tell that I feel ashamed, without telling the story?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I was hurt, and I am not worthless. What was done to me does not decide what I am worth.
- ☐ Shame is a feeling, not a measurement of my worth.
- ☐ I am not damaged goods.
- ☐ God is near me, not disgusted with me.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from the love of God.
- ☐ I can heal slowly without first proving I am clean.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 147:3
  "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."
- ☐ Isaiah 61:1
  "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When shame said you were worthless: Each day, write down one moment when you felt damaged beyond help. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 147:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God binds up the brokenhearted. I am hurt, and I am not worthless.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Separate the harm from your name. Write "What happened" and "Who I am" on two lines. Do not let the first rename the second. No details.
- ☐ Tell your counselor that shame says you are worthless. Let them help you go slowly.
- ☐ Receive one kindness this week without explaining why you do not deserve it.
- ☐ If the shame includes wanting to die, call or text 988, or tell someone near you today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I was not worthless
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I feel damaged and ashamed, as if what was done to me made me worthless. You bind up the brokenhearted. Teach me that I am still loved, and stay near while the shame is loud. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.